

California State University
Northridge

Graduate Project Guidelines in
Abstract form

Instructions for Preparation and Submission

CSUN Office of Graduate Studies

275 University Hall

Graduate Studies Homepage

(818) 677-4800

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California State University, Northridge

**INSTRUCTIONS FOR THE PREPARATION AND
SUBMISSION OF**

**GRADUATE PROJECTS IN
ABSTRACT FORM**

INTRODUCTION

The Thesis or Dissertation identified on the student's program is the culminating academic experience leading to an advanced degree. A Master's thesis is based on the results of original research, which substantiates a specific view as expressed in a hypothesis, a concept, or a question. A Master's thesis can consist of making a synthesis of existing data and/or the development of new data in the laboratory or in the library. The term *graduate project* is used to describe a piece of original, creative work which does not lend itself to a book format, e.g., paintings, films, or theatrical productions. Even in some disciplines and departments where the end result of the candidate's work is a bound report, the term *graduate project* is appropriate, since the candidate's subject matter and research have an applied orientation. Examples of such graduate projects might be found in the area of engineering, computer design and curricula development, and in the implementation of organizational structures in social systems.

A Master's thesis or graduate project provides a demonstration of a graduate student's ability to explore, develop, and organize materials relating to a specific problem or an applied orientation within a field of study. The student must exhibit the ability to pursue an extended scholarly statement in a clear, direct, and concise manner. The university retains an approved electronic version through Scholarworks@CSUN. This allows the work to be publicly available to other students, faculty, and outside researches. The thesis or the graduate project, therefore, becomes a visible and permanent measure of the quality of scholarship expected of a graduate student.

A written Doctoral Dissertation is the major benchmark required in CSUN's Doctoral program. All candidates complete a Dissertation based on a review of the literature and original research on a problem. The primary goal of the Dissertation is to generate applied knowledge that contributes to the understanding and improvement of practices, policies, or reforms. The Dissertation is a contribution to the field that demonstrates the candidate's scholarship, research skills, and insight into a particular problem.

The Doctoral Dissertation at CSUN is a significant scholarly work that uses rigorous research methods in the study of problems, practices and the application of problem-solving strategies. The Dissertation is expected to be based on one or more theoretical frameworks and to include a comprehensive review of relevant literature. The Dissertation typically involves collection of empirical data, qualitative and/or quantitative analysis of these data, interpretation of the findings, discussion of their significance and implications, and recommendations of important areas for action as well as further study.

The Graduate Studies Committee has adopted a body of regulations and criteria that establishes uniformity in physical format for all theses and dissertations submitted in fulfillment of requirements for advanced degrees. As a graduate student, not only are you required to follow the guidelines and specifications established by your department and committee for the completion of your thesis or dissertation, but you must also comply with the requirements of the Graduate Studies Committee concerning the physical format of your manuscript as established in these instructions. **Never use as a precedent dissertations or theses on file in the University Libraries or in your academic department because the manuscript requirements have changed over the years.**

Theses and Projects are to be submitted during the student's final semester, and the student must have enrollment during this semester. Before beginning work on a thesis or dissertation, you must receive approval of the proposed subject matter from the faculty committee in charge of your program. Your committee has responsibility for both the content and written style of the manuscript. You must receive approval in both areas. Style, including footnote and bibliographic form, is at the discretion of your committee so long as consistency is maintained throughout the manuscript. For assistance in resolving questions concerning style, you and your committee may consult established manuals of style (such as the *Chicago Manual of Style*, *Elements of Style* by Strunk and White, or the *MLA Style Sheet*) or manuals of style specific to your area of expertise (such as the *American Psychological Association Manual*). Using these style guides will help you, but be careful because Graduate Studies regulations may differ slightly.

GENERAL REQUIREMENTS AND APPROVAL PROCEDURES

This section outlines the responsibilities and procedures that students must follow with regard to the completion of a Graduate Project for a Master's degree. For additional questions, students should contact their graduate program coordinator or their committee chair. The following standards and procedures apply to all graduate programs at California State University, Northridge. The students, however, are required to check the standards and procedures required by their specific department or program. Graduate programs may have more stringent requirements than those of Graduate Studies.

Note: Only fully classified students are allowed to work on their culminating experience. Thus, conditionally classified students are not allowed to register for the ETD system. For more info on classification, please speak to the graduate coordinator of your department or visit the link: [Classified Status Policies](#)

REGISTERING ON THE ELECTRONIC THESIS DISSERTATION SYSTEM (ETD)

The first time you log into ETD, ([ETD Login](#)) you will be prompted to register. Click on the "Register Here" link and complete the Student Information page. Clicking the "Register" button will complete the registration page and bring you to your home page. From here, you will be able to complete your Planning Form. Upon successful completion of registration, deadlines for the Project Planning Form, Preliminary Draft and Final submissions will appear for your expected graduation semester. Students are responsible to adhere to these deadlines. For help with using the ETD system, see the online tutorial at: [ETD Help Desk](#)

JOINT PROJECT

A Joint project is comprised of no more than two students collaborating. The Joint Project requires an addendum, which must be turned in to the Graduate Studies Office. The addendum must identify the name(s) of co-author(s) and provide a detailed description of their responsibilities. The addendum must be approved by the students Project Committee members, Graduate Coordinator and Department Chair. This addendum form must be obtained at the Graduate Studies Office, UN 275. Each student in collaboration must submit an addendum. **The Joint Project Title page must also name the collaborating student.**

The Signature page, Dedication, Acknowledgment and Abstract is the student's individual work. Meaning these pages would not necessarily be identical to the co-author /collaborating student. Within the co-authors Table of Contents the Roman numeral section may vary (i.e. one author may choose to add a dedication page, while the other opts not to have a dedication).

From Arabic page 1 in a joint project chapters, headings and text must be identical throughout both authors' projects. Each student in collaboration must complete the submission process in ETD.

GRADUATE PROJECT COMMITTEE SELECTION

A minimum of three individuals who do not have a conflict of interest with the student, must serve on a student's committee. A conflict of interest is defined as a person who has an economic, sexual, and/or romantic involvement with the student or a member of the student's immediate family that could reasonably be perceived as impairing objectivity. The chair of the committee must be a tenured or tenure-track faculty member of the department or academic degree granting program. The majority of members of the committee must be active members of the department or program. Active members include all tenured and tenure-track faculty and lecturers affiliated with the department or program—as defined by the graduate coordinator. Faculty participating in the Faculty Early Retirement Program are considered active faculty members and, as such, can serve as either the chair or a committee member. Some departments or programs may have alternate policies approved by the Graduate Studies Committee. A minority of committee members may be drawn from outside the department or program, either from within or outside of the university. Like all committee members, such outside members must (a) have a graduate degree in a related field, or (b) have extensive experience in the topic, and (c) demonstrate professional recognition through publications, creative activities, reports, papers or membership in a national professional organization and/or working committees in their institution. Individuals from outside the university must submit a CV to, and be approved by, the graduate coordinator of the department or program. Once you have formed your committee, you will need to register through the Electronic Thesis and Dissertation (ETD) website. A curriculum vitae of a part-time faculty member or off-campus committee member must be uploaded electronically on the ETD website for approval by your committee chair, department graduate coordinator, and the Associate Vice President of Graduate Studies.

PROJECT PLANNING FORM AND APPROVAL OF TOPIC

Once you have formed your Graduate Project Committee, you will need to complete the Project Planning Form on the Electronic Thesis Dissertation (ETD) system, accessible at [ETD Login](#). The planning form is brief and requires basic information such as the title of your graduate project, the names of the members of your graduate project committee, and the email addresses of your committee members. Please use the campus email of any on campus committee members in order to avoid the email being sent to a spam folder. If for some reason a committee member does not receive an email from the ETD system, they can simply visit [ETD Homepage](#) to register and access ETD. If the wrong email is entered in the planning form, please call the IT department at (818) 677-1400 for assistance. For help using the ETD system, visit the online tutorial at: [ETD Help Desk](#).

Note: that the Curriculum Vitae for any off-campus member of your graduate project committee must be uploaded on the ETD system at this stage. Before starting your project, the student must obtain the approval of all members of his or her project committee.

PRELIMINARY DRAFT APPROVAL

The format review for your project is submitted electronically at [ETD login](#). Only after your planning form has been completed will you be permitted to submit your completed working preliminary draft for format review.

Preliminary draft stage requires that students have a completed working draft. **This means your Roman Numeral sections, all chapters, references, and appendices must be completed.**

Once you submit the draft, your Graduate Evaluator will be notified and your document will be reviewed. The Graduate Evaluator will review a complete online preliminary draft of your project to determine whether the format complies with all University requirements. If it does not, it will be rejected, and formal approval will be delayed until necessary revisions are made. Therefore, it is required that you resubmit a revised copy electronically of your thesis/dissertation for preliminary approval. Once the corrections are made to the document, it must be re-submitted to ETD at [ETD Login](#).

FINAL UPLOAD AND APPROVAL

FILE SIZE LIMIT

The final upload in ETD may not exceed **4GB** in size. This includes the thesis/dissertation/graduate project document as well as any supplementary materials the student decides to attach.

COMMITTEE APPROVAL

The document must be submitted to your Committee in a timely manner for each to read and suggest revisions prior to their final approval. Should your project require approval during a Summer Session, it is imperative that you coordinate in advance with your Committee in order to obtain their approval prior to the deadline. It is best for you to check with your committee members for department regulations, since departments often set additional deadlines. Your committee is required to certify the academic soundness of your work and verify that it meets the academic standards of the degree sought. Committee members must approve through the ETD system.

GRADUATE STUDIES APPROVAL

Your committee approved final draft must be submitted to ETD on or before the published deadline for the semester. The graduate project must be submitted as one PDF document. Once the steps above have been completed, the Office of Graduate Studies will review your final version and academic file for completion of degree requirements.

NOTE:

Your Master's Degree and Graduate Project cannot be approved or conferred until the end of the semester. Your Graduate Project will read "Awaiting GRIP Approval" on ETD after your committee members have approved of your final submission. Please check your unofficial transcripts to verify if your degree has been awarded. This may take several weeks following the conclusion of the semester.

FILING YOUR GRADUATE PROJECT

DEADLINES

Thesis/Project/Abstract Deadline

All graduate projects at CSUN must be submitted online to the ETD website. Email attachments, electronic files, and paper copies brought into the Graduate Studies office **cannot** be accepted. Dates for electronically filing your project with the Graduate Studies Office are published each semester on the Graduate Studies website at [ETD Deadlines](#) as well as on ETD when you register. **It is your responsibility to know and abide by these dates.** The deadline for filing with the Graduate Studies Office is always **5pm**. This deadline is strictly observed. Additional information regarding the submission of graduate projects can be found below. University policy requires that you must be an enrolled student the semester you graduate.

Graduation Deadline

Deadlines for submission of your Degree Completion & Diploma application students must apply for graduation the semester before they plan to graduate. The Application for Graduation is now available online. To be eligible to apply graduates will need to be in classified status and have completed or be in progress of completing 18 units. Students should apply a year in advance of their intended graduation date. The specific graduation deadlines for application submission appear in the link provided: [Deadlines to Apply to Graduate](#)

Note: If you need more time to complete degree requirements and has already submitted the Application for Graduate Degree and Diploma, you must submit a “Change of Date form” along with an \$8 processing fee. The form can be found on the CSUN Graduate Studies website under the “Forms” tab.

PUBLICATION EMBARGO

All CSUN graduate projects that are approved within the ETD system are made public within ScholarWorks. If you request to delay the release of your work, prior approval from the committee chair must be obtained. Students who use this option are typically planning to publish all or part of the thesis/dissertation in the near future. The longest delay CSUN will currently allow is 2 years

U.S. COPYRIGHT REGISTRATION AND PUBLICATION OF YOUR PROJECT

Under the Copyright Act of 1976, **your graduate project will automatically be copyrighted without notice or registration with the U.S. Copyright Office** and no one can legally copy your work without consent for your lifetime plus 70 years.

In order to register your work with the Library of Congress, you may obtain the necessary forms and information from <http://www.copyright.gov>. If you have questions about copyright law, please contact the U.S. Copyright Office (1-202-707-3000 or [Copyright.gov Website](http://www.copyright.gov)).

If your graduate work was supported by outside agencies, you may have special obligations with respect to copyrighting your graduate project. Please consult the conditions pertaining to the award for further clarification.

BINDING YOUR WORK

Binding your work is optional. Printed copies of projects are not currently being produced or required; therefore, you are not obligated to order bound copies. There are options for printed copies through companies, such as Kater Crafts, which have bound master's theses for CSUN in the past. If you do order printed copies from Kater Crafts, please keep in mind that it may take a few months before they arrive.

If your advisor or department would like a printed copy, you are responsible for creating the printed version of your graduate project. Quickcopies, on campus, for a fee, will print your graduate project, reduce your graphs, and bind any of your extra copies in a hard or soft format for your personal use. You may also opt to use another printing and binding company of your own choosing.

FINAL TRANSCRIPT AND DIPLOMA

Your official CSUN transcript, listing your master's degree, will be available approximately **4 weeks** after the date on which your master's degree was officially conferred. Your official transcript will not be generated automatically. Official transcripts can be ordered online

through the MyNorthridge portal. Transcripts can also be requested, in person, or by mail, with the request form from Admissions and Records.

Approximately 4-6 weeks after your official degree conferral date, you will receive your diploma via USPS to the address on SOLAR. Diplomas are mailed to the address listed in SOLAR. It is your responsibility to keep that address current. Otherwise, your diploma will be mailed to the wrong address and you will have to request, and pay for, another diploma. After graduation, and for an indefinite period of time, you will have access to: SOLAR, CSUN email account, and the MyNorthridge portal.

*Please note that the end of the semester is not the date of degree conferral, nor is commencement. Degrees may take several weeks following the end of the semester to be conferred.

NEED HELP?

The Graduate Studies Office is available Monday thru Friday from 8am to 5pm to answer any questions concerning interpretation of these instructions (818)-677-4800 or (graduate.studies@csun.edu). We are located in the University Hall, Room 275. You may also visit [Graduate Studies Homepage](#) for additional links and information.

Preparing the Manuscript

TYPE FACE/FONT SIZE

The type size used should be 10 or 12-point overall and should remain consistent throughout the document. A notable exception to this rule is in tables and figures. In tables and figures, the type may be slightly smaller.

The print should be black, and the characters consistently clear and dense. **Use Times New Roman throughout the manuscript.** Confirm that the typeface of your page numbers matches the text. Do not use script or italics as the main type face; use it only as necessary for book titles, Latin nomenclature, etc.

MARGINS

The margins of **one-inch (1”) on the left, and one-inch (1”) on the top, right, and bottom of the page** must be observed. Tables, charts, maps, illustrations as well as appendices must have the same margins.

The choice of whether or not to justify the right-hand margin is up to students and their committees. We suggest that you use right-justified margins only if your software program does this well and does not leave large gaps in the text or separate punctuation from text characters.

SPACING

For spacing, we recommend that you contact your committee chair in regards to a stylistic preference. The following text, may be single-spaced:

- ❖ Captions
- ❖ Footnotes
- ❖ Long quotations (those of more than three lines)
- ❖ Bibliography entries of more than one line
- ❖ Materials in tables and appendices (text in appendices should be double-spaced)

A blank line must appear between footnotes and bibliography entries. The text must be arranged so that gaps or white spaces within major sections are minimal. The only blank space should be appearing at the end of major sections when necessary to allow the first typing of the next major section to begin on a new page.

Avoid widows (one line of text from the end of a paragraph appearing alone at the top of a

sheet of paper) and orphans (one line of text from the beginning of a paragraph appearing alone at the bottom of a sheet of paper or a heading or subheading at the bottom of a page that is not followed immediately by text on that page). There should be at least two lines of text at the top and bottom of each page.

HEADINGS

Main headings should be centered 1 inch from the top of the page. Be consistent within each chapter/section. All main headings should either be **Bold**, unbold AND ALL CAPS, or First Letter of Each Major Word is capitalized.

Subheadings are a freestanding side heading; please contact your committee chair regarding a stylistic preference. Whatever the selected format, **be consistent within each chapter/section**. The subheading must either be Underlined, *Italics*, or in **Bold** print. **Only one of these styles may be used at a time.**

PAGINATION

Graduate projects are to be paginated as follows:

- ❖ **Preliminary pagination:** The title page is **counted** in the pagination but the number **IS NOT** printed on the page. All other preliminary pages are numbered with lower case Roman numerals centered on the text at the bottom of the page below the margin line, starting with “ii.” If there is a copyright page, the numeral will be “ii” with the following signature page numbered “iii”. If there is not a copyright page then the following signature page will begin with the numeral “ii”.
- ❖ **Main body:** Graduate projects in abstract form do not have a main body containing chapters as the content is covered in the abstract and preliminary pages. If the preliminary pages exceed Roman numeral ten (X), then Arabic numbering will follow for any remaining pages with the first Arabic numbered page being 1. Page numbers are centered on the text at the bottom of the page, below the margin line (or centered between the bottom margin and the bottom of the page). The numbers should appear without periods, parentheses, or dashes. Pages that are landscape oriented must still have a portrait style page number.

LANGUAGE CONSIDERATIONS

The graduate project must be written in the English language. If you are required to use excerpts in a different language, the English translation must immediately follow.

FORMAT OF THE GRADUATE PROJECT

After your committee members have read and have given preliminary approval of your graduate project, the final draft is to be prepared using the following format:

PRELIMINARY PAGES: OVERVIEW

Preliminary pagination: The title is counted in the pagination but the number is not printed on the title page. Make sure that you use the word “Graduate Project” on your preliminary pages.

Preliminary pages include (in the following order):

- ❖ Title page – required for graduate projects
- ❖ Copyright page – optional
- ❖ Unsigned Signature Page – required for graduate projects
- ❖ Preface/Forward - optional
- ❖ Acknowledgments – optional
- ❖ Dedication – optional
- ❖ Table of Contents – required for graduate projects
- ❖ List of Figures – optional
- ❖ Abstract – required for graduate projects

TITLE PAGE

Your graduate project must include a title page. See Appendix A for a sample title page. Do not use any stylized text on your title page (italics may be allowed for Latin nomenclature). **No bold type!** Note that while the title page is counted in the pagination, it **should not** have a printed number.

- ❖ **Graduate project title** - The rules for capitalization in the title are strict. The first, last, all principal words, and words with 4 letters or more must have the first letter capitalized, including those that follow hyphens in compound terms. The only words that should not be capitalized are articles (a, an, the), prepositions (e.g., in, to), and conjunctions (e.g., and, but, for) with fewer than 4 letters. Use word substitutes for formulas, symbols, superscripts, Greek letters, or other non-alphabetical symbols in the title.
- ❖ **Degree name** - The degree name on the title page may be: Master of Arts in Art, or Master of Fine Arts in Art, or Master of Music.
- ❖ **Program name** - Program name is the degree program plan that is listed on your University record. For example, if your major is English, do not list English Literature on your title page. Note: Not all options/emphasis or concentrations are listed.
- ❖ **Your official name** - The name used on the title page is your name **exactly** as it is found on your University record. If you wish to record your name in a different manner, you must first file a name change petition with the Office of Admissions and Records.
- ❖ **Date** - The month and year the degree is to be conferred or awarded. Degrees are conferred three times per year: in December, May, and August.

COPYRIGHT PAGE

A Copyright page is not required, but optional. See Appendix B for correct format.

SIGNATURE PAGE

The signature page involves the electronic version that does not require actual signatures. The electronic version of the document must include an unsigned formatted signature page.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS AND/OR DEDICATION

You may want to include an acknowledgment of help received from particular people or a brief note of dedication. Such notes should follow at this point. If you are using published material in the main body of the manuscript, you must enclose an acknowledgment indicating where your work has been published. Do not include acknowledgments at the end of each chapter.

This page should be numbered using lower case Roman numerals. If you choose to include both Acknowledgments and Dedication, they should be on separate pages, with the Acknowledgment page appearing first. The text of these pages must be double-spaced.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Each graduate project is expected to have a table of contents for the convenience of the reader. There is no specific format that students must follow in this case. The table of contents should be easy to read, consistent and have page numbers listed on the right side of the page. The table of contents must include page numbers for the preliminary pages, with the exception of the table of contents. A typical table of contents does not exceed 3 pages.

ABSTRACTS FOR PROJECTS

Candidates in Art and Music, who present an artistic performance or other creative work in lieu of a thesis, are required to upload an abstract of their performance or other creative work in the ETD system. The advisory committee will determine the content, length, and organization of the abstract.

Art

In the case of an art exhibit, photographs of work are to be included in the Appendix. Art History projects must follow the requirements for graduate projects as they contain a main body with chapters.

Music

Music composition/performance recording should be uploaded as a supporting document in the Electronic Thesis Dissertation (ETD) system

APPENDICES

The appendix section will follow the abstract and may contain the actual project. For example, it might include images of the project that would help the reader to understand the student's work. The appendices must fall within the margin requirements and may be single-spaced if necessary.

The ETD website also gives students the option to upload "Supporting Files" in addition to your graduate project. Supplemental files can include large appendix type material, videos, images, audio files, PowerPoint presentations, and any other file type, which will not be embedded into the main graduate project document.

GRADUATE PROJECT CHRONOLOGY

Major steps that each Master's degree student completing a graduate project should follow are:

1. Select, in consultation with your graduate coordinator or advisor, the members of your Graduate Project Committee. Do this as soon as you attain Classified Status.
2. Register in the Electronic Thesis Dissertation (ETD) system and complete the Planning Form through the ETD system. [ETD Login](#)
3. If you are using human subjects or animals to test your hypothesis, read the appropriate material in these guidelines and obtain your approvals to use human or animal subjects prior to collecting data for your Graduate Project.
4. Upload your Graduate Project to the ETD system for preliminary approval on formatting.
5. Upload a final Graduate Project on the ETD system after receiving preliminary approval.

NOTE:

The 'RP' grade given for your Graduate Project MUST be converted by your Committee Chair in order for your graduation process to be completed.

COMMON ERRORS FOUND ON GRADUATE PROJECTS

Entire Manuscript:

Incorrect margins
Page numbers not printed below the margin line

Title Page:

Incorrect capitalization of title
Wrong degree and/or major listed
Name does not match University records
Inaccurate degree conferral date
Printed page number (title page does not have a page number)
Bold/Italics/Underlining

Copyright:

Name does not match University records
Missing page number (Copyright page requires a roman numeral)
Bold/Italics/Underlining

Signature:

Name does not match University records
Missing page number (signature page requires a roman numeral)
Bold/Italics/Underlining

Acknowledgments/Dedications:

Body is not double spaced
Page number missing or is not lower case
Roman numeral
Acknowledgment and Dedication are not on separate pages
Bold/Italics/Underlining

Table of Contents:

Not included
Page number missing or is not a lower case
Bold/Italics/Underlining
Roman Numeral missing or not lower case

Abstract:

Abstract title does not match title page
Incorrect capitalization of title
Wrong date/name/degree listed
Body exceeds 350 words or 2,450 characters
Page number missing or is not a lower case
Roman numeral
Bold/Italics/Underlining

Text:

Page numbering does not begin with 1
Text is not double-spaced
Inconsistent Heading Style

Footnotes/Endnotes/Bibliography:

Entries are not single-spaced
There is no blank line between each entry
Bibliography does not begin on a new page

Graphs/Tables/Illustrations:

Incorrect margins
Type is too small to read
Page number is missing
Landscape pages not oriented correctly
Page number is not portrait style

Appendices:

Page numbers do not continue
Incorrect margins

Sample

Appendix A *Sample Title Page*

CALIFORNIA STATE UNIVERSITY, NORTHRIDGE

Obsessed: A Graduate Voice Recital

A graduate project submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements
For the degree of Master of Music in Music Performance

By
Jane Doe

May 2013
(Official end of the semester)

Appendix B

Sample Title Page-Joint Theses

CALIFORNIA STATE UNIVERSITY, NORTHRIDGE

Life as a Culminating Experience

A graduate project submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements
For the degree of Master of Social Work

By

Jane Doe

in collaboration with
Robert Russell Johnson

May 2013
(Official end of the semester)

Appendix C
Sample Copyright Page

Copyright by Jane Doe 2013

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Appendix D

Sample Signature Page

The graduate project of Jane Doe is approved:

Dr. Clark Kent

Date

Dr. Charles Xavier

Date

Dr. Bruce Banner, Chair

Date

Note: You should check with your committee members to find out how they wish to be referred to on your signature page- Professor, Dr., and so on. Committee Chair is last on list and noted as chair.

California State University, Northridge

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(or iii if you have a copyright page)

Appendix E *Sample* Table of Contents

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Appendix F
Sample Abstract

Abstract

Obsessed: A Graduate Voice Recital

By
Jane Doe

Master of Music in Music Performance

Begin typing abstract here...